

This is the accepted version of a paper forthcoming in China Perspectives; it has not been copy-edited or typeset, and the published version should be cited.

The Repression Matrix: Non-Spectacular Coercion and Feminist Demobilization in China

Lü Pin

Lü Pin is a PhD candidate in Political Science at Rutgers University. Her research focuses on social movements, gender politics, and authoritarianism in China. Outside academia, she has been working for the feminist movement in China for nearly 30 years.

Email:pin.lu@rutgers.edu

Abstract

Authoritarian states can demobilize social movements without resorting to spectacular crackdowns. This paper traces that pattern through China's feminist movement between 2013 and 2023, when activists were rarely imprisoned en masse yet the organized dimension of the movement significantly contracted. The paper theorizes the repression matrix, a coordinated repressive network that the security apparatus deploys across the everyday institutions and relationships in which activists live, rendering their ordinary conditions untenable and foreclosing their potential for action. Interviews with 25 activists and movement archives document the matrix identifying targets, distributing enforcement, and normalizing extralegal practices. Each works through structural vulnerabilities feminist activists inhabit. The findings advance scholarship on repression by tracing its power to socially embedded dispersion and strategic deniability.

Keywords

Repression; Feminism; Social movements; Authoritarianism; Demobilization; Everyday repression; Gender; State violence; Repression matrix

Introduction

Since Xi Jinping assumed power in 2012, the Chinese state has intensified repression against challengers to its authority, particularly those engaged in civic activism (Fu 2017; Zhu and Lu 2022). Yet the state does not repress all movements equally. Some have faced large-scale, repeated, and severe criminalization. Human rights lawyers offer the most prominent example: in the 2015 “709 crackdown”, they experienced mass arrests, prolonged detention, public trials, and televised confessions (Fu 2018). Uyghur intellectuals were also subjected to mass incarceration during this period, with sentences extending to life imprisonment.¹ Other movements have faced far less systematic prosecution and mass arrests, labor and feminist movements among them, yet have also experienced significant decline in organizational capacity and collective action (Franceschini and Nesossi 2018; Fincher 2016), even as spontaneous protests continue as in labor activism or discursive influence persists as in feminism. This pattern raises a puzzle: how does demobilization occur without mass criminalization?

Scholarship on authoritarian repression has documented a shift from spectacular, violent crackdowns toward covert, socially embedded, and strategically ambiguous measures to neutralize opposition while minimizing political costs and risks (Earl 2011; Gerschewski 2013). Extending this scholarship, this paper theorizes a particular mode of repression under Chinese authoritarian conditions, rendering conditions of ordinary life—education, employment, housing, livelihood, personal mobility, social relationships—punitively unstable for dissidents, preventing activists from sustaining their cause and thereby dismantling their movements.

¹ Bahram K. Sintash, *Detained and Disappeared: Intellectuals Under Assault in the Uyghur Homeland*, Uyghur Human Rights Project, 2019, <https://docs.uhrp.org/pdf/Detained-and-Disappeared-Intellectuals-Under-Assault-in-the-Uyghur-Homeland.pdf> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

I use the term “repression matrix” to describe a dispersed yet coordinated system operating through the collaboration of multiple actors: police, administrative agencies, universities, employers, landlords, and others. Rather than constructing new coercive mechanisms, the matrix activates hierarchies and dependencies already embedded in social life, exploiting administrative systems, housing markets, workplace relationships, and community networks to constrict activists’ possibilities and generate cumulative suffering.

I examine these dynamics through China’s feminist movement between 2013 and 2023, the first decade of Xi’s rule. This case offers a critical site for analyzing non-spectacular repression. On one hand, feminists clearly faced state hostility: the 2015 detention of the “Feminist Five” signaled that authorities viewed feminist organizing as politically threatening.² On the other hand, this hostility rarely translated into systematic criminal prosecution. Apart from a few prominent cases, most notably the 2024 sentencing of #MeToo journalist Huang Xueqin, feminist activists were not imprisoned en masse.³ Yet by the early 2020s, the organized dimension of the movement had significantly contracted, reduced to a state of managed marginalization (Liao 2025).

What occurred during these years was that feminist activists encountered low-profile, multi-sourced, yet persistent and profoundly painful interventions: “tea” summons by police and state security agencies⁴, forced evictions, bureaucratic obstruction, community surveillance, mobility restrictions, and pressure exerted through employers, advisors, parents, and others who held power over them in everyday relationships.⁵ These tactics functioned as

² “Meet the 5 Female Activists China Has Detained,” The New York Times, 6 April 2015, <https://cn.nytimes.com/china/20150406/c06womenprofiles/> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

³ “Chinese #MeToo Journalist Huang Xueqin Sentenced to Five Years in Prison,” The Guardian, 14 June 2024, <https://www.theguardian.com/world/article/2024/jun/14/chinese-metoo-journalist-huang-xueqin-sentenced-to-five-years-in-prison> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

⁴ In China, public security (gong’an 公安) and state security (guo’an 國安) are two distinct systems that both participate in the repression of civic activism. In practice, targets are often unable to distinguish which agency they are confronting. Interviewees therefore frequently refer to “the police” generically.

⁵ See: “China’s ‘Invited to Tea’ Crackdown on Activists,” Radio Free Asia, 15 March 2011, <https://www.rfa.org/english/news/china/tea-03152011103327.html> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

a coherent system, progressively dismantling the material, relational, and psychological foundations of activists' lives and work.

This paper advances understanding of authoritarian repression by demonstrating how demobilization can be achieved without spectacular crackdowns. I show how authoritarian power achieves effectiveness through strategic dispersion and deniability. The analysis also foregrounds a dimension that has received insufficient attention: the dependence of such repression on pre-existing social stratification. In societies where housing, employment, and social standing depend on conformity to structural norms and administrative status, this mode of repression can achieve demobilization while remaining invisible as political persecution.

The paper proceeds as follows: a review of scholarship on authoritarian repression; case selection, research design, and data; the structure of the repression matrix and the structural vulnerabilities that shape activists' exposure; a longitudinal case study of one activist's trajectory; and a conclusion on how authoritarian power operates when it chooses not to criminalize.

Literature review: Repression beyond spectacle

Authoritarian regimes rely on repression to maintain political order, but repression often produces unintended consequences, including public backlash, elite alienation, and international sanctions (Svolik 2012). This "repression paradox" (Magaloni 2008) has compelled many regimes to recalibrate their coercive strategies. One notable shift has been the increasing use of low-intensity repression, a mode of control that is subtle, routinized, and cost-efficient (Greitens 2016; Levitsky and Way 2010). This does not mean regimes abandon overt violence; rather, they retain it as a latent threat while relying primarily on dispersed, socially embedded measures to achieve demobilization. The goal is not to eliminate dissent but to weaken mobilization capacity and shift movements toward defensive, non-threatening modes (Moss 2014).

Scholarship has identified several features of this non-spectacular approach: repression operationalized through multi-actor networks extending beyond state agencies (Earl 2003; Ferree 2004); exploitation of embedded social structures such as families, workplaces, and communities (Deng and O'Brien 2013; Mattingly 2019); selective targeting of key organizers (Davenport 2007; Earl 2011); and strategic ambiguity that obscures boundaries and hinders resistance (Stern and Hassid 2012; Stern and O'Brien 2012).

Research on China's "stability maintenance" (維穩 *weiwēn*) system and civil society repression demonstrates how non-spectacular repression operates under Chinese institutional conditions. Against episodic contenders—petitioners, protesters, aggrieved citizens—the stability maintenance system deploys a multi-layered apparatus of control. The "one-vote veto" pressure system creates powerful incentives for local officials to prevent collective incidents at all costs (Cai 2008; Lee and Zhang 2013), while centralized top-down oversight minimizes slack and ensures enforcement (Scoggins 2021). Street-level police exercise broad discretion, relying on informal methods that leave no documentation (Scoggins and O'Brien 2016). Community governance structures—residential committees, property management, neighborhood networks—together with work units and employers, extend state reach deep into daily life (Read 2012; Bray 2005). This apparatus operates preemptively, intervening before contention materializes rather than reacting afterward (Ritter 2014).

Among organized civil society, organizations perceived as threatening are selectively targeted while others are tolerated, maintaining strategic ambiguity that keeps all actors uncertain of boundaries (Hildebrandt 2013). Legal frameworks create gray zones where activities can be arbitrarily deemed illegal (Pils 2018; Gallagher 2017). Administrative measures—registration restrictions, forced relocations, tax inspections, venue cancellations—harass without formal prosecution (Teets 2014; Howell 2019). Resource infrastructures are systematically severed: funding channels blocked, legal status denied, international connections criminalized (Spires 2011). When organizations are dismantled, their members

face divergent fates: co-optation, quiescence, or persistence through atomized and underground forms of organizing (Franceschini and Lin 2019; O'Brien 2023).

Together, these literatures reveal that the Chinese state commands a spectrum of repressive measures, from brutal to seemingly benign, flexibly calibrated against different populations (Johnston 2019). Yet two gaps remain. Research on the *weiwen* system has focused on episodic contenders (petitioners, protesters, aggrieved individuals), paying less attention to sustained, organized activism that persists without crossing into overt confrontation. Studies of civil society repression have emphasized organizational-level dynamics, leaving underexplored the individual-level experience of activists: how dispersed pressures accumulate in daily life, erode the capacity to continue, and ultimately reshape political subjectivity. This paper addresses both gaps by examining how the repression matrix operates through the sustained degradation of individuals' ordinary conditions that make activism possible.

Conceptualizing the repression matrix

Drawing on insights from repression scholarship in and beyond China's context, I use the term "repression matrix" to describe a dispersed yet coordinated pattern of coercion that activates embedded social structures. The term "matrix" captures how repression operates not as a linear confrontation between state and dissidents but as an interlocking network of coercion enacted across multiple institutional sites—workplaces, neighborhoods, households, community networks. This framing highlights three key dynamics: how multiple actors coordinate through formal directives and tacit alignments of interest; how pre-existing social hierarchies are exploited to extend control; and how repression renders ordinary life conditions precarious, achieving demobilization through cumulative pressure rather than singular coercive events.

The matrix's operation depends on specific structural conditions. First, it operates within an institutional environment in which access to life necessities such as housing, employment, and education appears to be governed by market mechanisms and administrative rules yet remains largely unprotected by enforceable legal rights. Rental contracts can be terminated without cause, employment can be ended arbitrarily, community administrators exercise broad discretion, and legal recourse is limited or inaccessible. Characteristic of partial marketization under authoritarianism, where markets operate without robust rule of law (Gallagher 2017), this environment allows ostensibly rule-based and marketized systems to be manipulated for political purposes.

Second, the matrix presupposes the state's infrastructural penetration of social institutions (Mann 1984; Mattingly 2019). The party-state maintains pre-installed organizational interfaces within virtually every domain of social life: party committees and security departments inside universities and enterprises, residential committees and grid management covering urban neighborhoods (Read 2012; Bray 2005), real-name registration and data-sharing obligations binding internet platforms. The existence of these interfaces means that when the security apparatus seeks to mobilize an employer, a university, or a community, it does not need to construct a channel of transmission. It inherits one. The matrix, in this sense, does not create its own network but activates a network that the infrastructural state has already laid down.

Third, the matrix operates most effectively where institutional structures grant the state comprehensive reach over daily life, as with the household registration system that determines residence rights (Chan and Buckingham 2008), while limiting access to independent support networks. These arrangements embed a baseline vulnerability in everyone's ordinary existence, yet this latent precarity is activated only when individuals engage in resistance. Those who challenge political authority discover that what appeared as

stable foundations of life, including housing tenure, employment security, educational access, and community support, can be systematically withdrawn.

Within the matrix, actors are unequally positioned. Its internal architecture rests on an asymmetry between initiation and enforcement. The security apparatus alone initiates, coordinates, and supervises repression, monopolizing the intelligence on which targeting decisions rest. Enforcement, by contrast, is dispersed across two outer tiers: state agencies and affiliated institutions, whose cooperation is secured through the bureaucratic accountability structures of stability maintenance, and private or social actors, who are conscripted through dependency and fear yet control the domains of daily life that state power cannot directly reach. Coordination across these tiers flows through formal directives, through tacit signals and anticipated compliance (Stern and Hassid 2012), and through documentation practices that allow upper nodes to verify lower-node performance.

What enables the security apparatus to occupy this initiating position is its generalized capacity to punish (Greitens 2016). This capacity rests on three institutional foundations. First, the public security system in particular controls administrative gateways of ordinary life, including household registration, identity documents, and the security and licensing inspections on which businesses and institutions depend, and it commands broad discretionary powers of administrative punishment exercisable without trial (Biddulph 2007; Scoggins and O'Brien 2016). Second, within the stability maintenance system the police act as carriers of political priority, backed by the party's direct management of its coercive institutions (Wang 2014; Wang and Minzner 2015): for a university, an employer, or a local bureau, declining a police request registers as a political failure that can trigger accountability consequences. Third, the near absence of judicial remedy against public security renders police threats credible without formal authorization (Minzner 2011).

The matrix's deployment follows a graduated logic. Its components constitute a repertoire, deployed incrementally and in proportion to the assessed harm a target poses.

Escalation proceeds along two dimensions. The first is the widening conscription of third parties: repression begins dyadically, with warnings and informal police summons directed at the target alone, and expands to activate ever more nodes, from family members to employers, landlords, universities, and platforms, with the sequence of activation depending on which of a target's dependencies are most exploitable. The second is the deepening materiality of intervention: early interventions are communicative and reversible, warnings that cost the state little and the target nothing beyond fear, whereas later interventions degrade the material conditions of life, including employment, housing, and documents, in ways that are difficult to undo. Escalation is responsive, tracking the state's evolving assessment of the harm a target poses: the immediate harm of ongoing mobilization, and the longer-term harm of a persistent organizer whose influence may accumulate.

Because the repression matrix operates by activating embedded social structures, its deployment can take various patterns depending on which hierarchies and dependencies are most exploitable in a given context. Against labor activists, the matrix might primarily exploit workplace hierarchies and class-based vulnerabilities; against professionals, it might leverage institutional affiliations and reputational concerns; against ethnic minorities, it might activate kinship networks and community surveillance systems. The specific mechanisms through which the matrix operates are contingent on the social positioning of targeted individuals and the structural arrangements available for manipulation.

Case selection, research design, and data resources

This study examines repression experienced by Chinese feminist activists between 2013 and 2023, a period marked by Xi Jinping's consolidation of authoritarian rule and intensified suppression of civil society (Chen 2020; Wang and Minzner 2015). China's feminist movement offers a productive empirical site for analyzing how non-spectacular repression operates through embedded social structures. Three features make this case particularly instructive.

First, the movement's trajectory provides temporal variation. Chinese feminism shifted from state-sponsored institutions toward autonomous civil-society activism in the 1990s-2000s (Xu 2009; Yang 1999); by the 2010s, younger feminists employed digital mobilization and public advocacy, and the 2018 #MeToo movement generated national attention (Chen and Wang 2020; Li et al. 2021). This visibility triggered intensified state response.

Second, repression under Xi Jinping exemplifies the non-spectacular, high-frequency pattern this paper examines, and its evolution illuminates how repressive strategies adapt. Relative tolerance ended with the 2015 detention of the "Feminist Five," which signaled that authorities now viewed feminist organizing as politically subversive. Repression subsequently shifted from targeting organizations to targeting individuals, from visible crackdowns to chronic daily pressure. The 2018 #MeToo movement prompted intensified digital surveillance and preemptive repression (Liao and Luqiu 2022), and the COVID-19 pandemic supplied new instruments, from public health justifications to enhanced digital tracking. Cases like the 2024 sentencing of Huang Xueqin illustrate persistent punitive control, yet the dominant strategy remains managed marginalization rather than systematic prosecution.

Third, feminist activists occupy a structural position that makes repressive mechanisms particularly observable. They rely on precarious arrangements (rental housing, freelance employment, non-familial support networks) that create multiple points of leverage, and they organize through small, trust-based communities vulnerable to tactics that fragment social networks. This convergence of vulnerabilities makes visible mechanisms that might operate less detectably against other populations.

This study operationalizes demobilization at the individual level: whether activists continue, reduce, or cease their involvement. Movement-level outcomes, from declining organizational capacity to reduced collective action, are produced through the aggregation of individual trajectories, so individual-level data provide a window into the mechanisms of

movement-level demobilization. I focus on self-identified feminist activists: those who publicly embrace feminist politics and actively engage in organizing, advocacy, and movement-building, excluding general supporters or survivors who do not identify as activists. All participants are women, based on the observation that although activists of all genders face repression, gender significantly shapes the nature of their experiences (Tripp 2010).

The study draws on three data sources. First, I conducted in-depth interviews with 25 feminist activists between February and March 2025. Most participants are personally known to me in the movement; others were referred through snowball sampling. The majority were highly educated, urban-based women aged 22 to 49 (average 34), with involvement in activism averaging about 12 years; three were detained in 2015. Due to travel restrictions and safety concerns, interviews were conducted via Zoom and lasted one to two hours. For one participant, I developed a life history (Della Porta 2014) that traces the matrix's operation and its cumulative effects over more than a decade. To protect interviewees, I have obscured potentially identifying information. Second, I curated 20 first-person narratives authored by my interviewees, originally circulated on social media and since censored but preserved in digital repositories and feminist-curated archives; these corroborate and supplement the interview data. Third, I incorporated independent media accounts and reports, expanding the documented cases to 40 verifiable individuals. While not exhaustive or statistically representative, this archive captures significant cases of sustained repression across multiple sites and periods.

I selected quotations and narratives based on thematic recurrence, illustrative clarity, and conceptual richness. Following scholarship that conceptualizes testimonies as sites of knowledge production (Hiner 2018; Sutton 2018), I approach these narratives as strategies of meaning-making through which activists interpret, resist, and endure repression.

The structure of the repression matrix

Identification and assessment

The matrix's operation begins when activists come to state attention. Identification occurs through multiple channels. Digital surveillance systems monitor social media for feminist content, tracking who organizes events, publishes advocacy posts, or participates in online campaigns. Authorities also obtain information through infiltration of internal activities—undercover personnel attending workshops, screenings, or private gatherings—or through reports from informants embedded within activist networks.⁶ Additionally, activists already under interrogation are pressured to provide lists of contacts, participants, and organizers, forcing them to become unwilling sources of intelligence about their peers.⁷

Identification is often triggered by a single event—participation in a protest, co-organizing a workshop, publishing a widely-circulated article. But once identified, activists enter a system of persistent monitoring and recalibration. One interviewee described this realization:

I felt like I was on an invisible list. From that moment, the world was different. I was always being watched, always waiting for the next intervention.⁸

Once identified, activists undergo ongoing assessment that evaluates both their threat level and their vulnerabilities. Authorities observe activists' roles in networks: who initiates activities, who has broad reach, who coordinates across groups. They monitor associations—which causes activists align with, which sensitive issues they engage in, who their collaborators are.

⁶ Interviewees are identified by assigned codes (J1 to J25). Interview with J16, J25.

⁷ Interview with J5, J25.

⁸ Interview with J25.

Crucially, assessment also involves systematic probing of activists' private lives to identify exploitable vulnerabilities. Police may conduct lengthy and wide-ranging interrogations, asking about details of every aspect of activists' lives, requiring them to provide names of various contacts and relationships, and inspecting their phone communications. They also display knowledge of intimate details—daily routines, frequented locations, even pets—demonstrating surveillance depth and using this to warn those being questioned to remain honest and cooperative.⁹

This assessment is continuously recalibrated. As activists' visibility increases, perceived threat levels escalate. As life circumstances change—a new job, a move to a different city, a relationship shift—the vulnerability map is updated. From activists' perspective, this ongoing assessment creates a pervasive sense of exposure:

They know everything about me. Where I'm vulnerable, who I care about, what I can't afford to lose.¹⁰

Activation of multi-actor networks

From the perspective of those targeted, how the matrix mobilizes multiple actors to target specific activists remains largely opaque. Activists cannot witness the directives, phone calls, or institutional communications that set enforcement in motion. Yet they experience the effects: coordinated interventions that arrive at suspicious moments, involving institutions or individuals with whom they previously had no conflicts. How do we know these dispersed interventions constitute a coordinated matrix rather than independent actions by autonomous actors?

Sometimes coordination reveals itself explicitly. Landlords acknowledge police contact:

⁹ Interview with J5, J8, J10, J25.

¹⁰ Interview with J5.

The landlord called us to move out because the police had contacted her. She works in a public institution, and this would affect her.¹¹

University administrators invoke “instructions from above” when talking to students to discourage their actions.¹²

More often, coordination manifests through temporal synchronization. In one case, when two activists were advised by police to relocate and within days faced eviction demands, coincidence becomes implausible.¹³ Physical presence also indicates coordination. In one case, when a landlord demanded an activist vacate immediately, the activist recalled:

The police stood by, speaking gently to him: ‘Calm down, take care of your health.’ I was furious, but what could I do? They hid behind the landlord.¹⁴

Cross-jurisdictional tracking reveals information sharing across the security apparatus. Activists who relocate to new cities find that local police already possess detailed knowledge of their histories—where they had lived, what they had done, who their associates were.¹⁵

Evidence of top-down directives is sometimes direct, sometimes indirect. Those carrying out repression often appear unaware of the reasons behind their actions, clearly acting under orders. One activist recalled: “Once, the property management people were drunk and didn’t know why they were there, thinking I was engaged in prostitution”.¹⁶ Police spend considerable time filling out reports in front of activists and repeatedly confirm details with

¹¹ Interview with J1.

¹² Interview with J18.

¹³ Xiao Meili 肖美麗, “國寶請‘喝茶’到底要聊啥——問國寶的 5 個問題” (Guobao qing ‘he cha’ daodi yao liao sha—wen guobao de 5 ge wenti, What Do the Secret Police Want to Talk About When They Invite You to ‘Drink Tea’—5 Questions for the Secret Police), China Digital Times, 2017, <https://chinadigitaltimes.net/chinese/562274.html> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

¹⁴ Xiao Meili 肖美麗, “一塊廣告牌——中國地鐵反性騷擾廣告運動” (Yi kuai guanggaopai—Zhongguo ditie fan xingsaorao guanggao yundong, A Billboard—China’s Subway Anti-Sexual Harassment Ad Campaign), China Digital Times, 2018, <https://chinadigitaltimes.net/chinese/595704.html> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

¹⁵ Interview with J3.

¹⁶ Interview with J11.

them, evidently to satisfy oversight requirements. Various actors may request to take photos with their targets, apparently to prove task completion, and will resort to covert photography when refused.

The opacity of this coordination is itself a mechanism of control. Because activists cannot identify who initiated these actions or trace decision-making chains, they cannot effectively contest the process. Was the eviction the landlord's independent decision or police pressure? Did the university decide autonomously to block academic progress, or did it respond to security directives? This deliberate ambiguity renders resistance futile—there is no clear target to challenge, no documentation to appeal, no procedural pathway to justice.

Distributed enforcement through multiple actors

Once activated, the matrix operates through diverse actors who deploy different forms of pressure based on their institutional positions and access to different domains of activists' lives. This distributed enforcement reveals how ordinary administrative procedures and everyday relationships are transformed into instruments of political control.

As the matrix's initiating and supervising node, police and state security agencies possess recognized authority to directly execute repression. They conduct interrogations, impose travel restrictions, maintain surveillance, and document activists' activities. At the same time, they have the power to issue requests or directives—sometimes formal, often informal—thereby mobilizing other institutions and individuals to participate and overseeing their execution. When activists refuse to comply with informal summons, police demonstrate their reach:

The police suddenly called me to go to the police station. I said I wouldn't go, that it was a scam (...) An hour later, the police directly knocked on my company door calling my name and took me away.¹⁷

State departments and affiliated institutions weaponize ostensibly routine or apolitical administrative and bureaucratic procedures. Public health bureaus issue pandemic-related eviction orders targeting activists under the guise of disease control.¹⁸ Administrations for industry and commerce deny business registrations or revoke licenses for feminist enterprises, citing technical violations.¹⁹ Cultural authorities cancel event permits or shut down screenings, invoking vague regulatory requirements.²⁰ Universities block thesis defenses and refuse to grant degrees through internal disciplinary procedures.²¹ The effectiveness of these interventions lies in their ability to create trouble through unexpected yet dependent aspects of life.

Private actors extend enforcement into intimate spheres: landlords terminate leases; employers end contracts;²² property management intensifies monitoring. One activist described: "The security guard at my residential complex was an informant, reporting my whereabouts to the local police for a long time".²³ Internet platforms coordinate with authorities to delete accounts and share user data.²⁴ Remote participants engage in doxxing

¹⁷ Interview with J17.

¹⁸ Interview with J9.

¹⁹ Interview with J3; "廣州性別教育中心被關閉" (Guangzhou xingbie jiaoyu zhongxin bei guanbi, Guangzhou Gender Education Center Shut Down), Radio Free Asia, 7 December 2018, <https://www.rfa.org/mandarin/yataibaodao/renquanfazhi/nu-12072018102010.html> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

²⁰ Interview with J15.

²¹ Interview with J11.

²² Interview with J12.

²³ Interview with J21.

²⁴ Keith Bradsher, "China's Feminists, Once Celebrated, Are Now Censored and Silenced," The New York Times, 6 May 2024, <https://www.nytimes.com/2024/05/06/world/asia/china-feminists-censorship.html> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

and online harassment (Huang 2023). Activists face pressure from actors they may never have physically encountered.

From activists' perspective, this distributed enforcement creates a bewildering multiplication of pressure points. Virtually any institutional interaction or social relationship can become a site of control, and every domain of daily life transforms from taken-for-granted infrastructure into contested terrain, where the state can intervene through proxies who claim to act within their normal bureaucratic or contractual authority.

These actors participate for varying reasons. Police and security officers act under official mandate—following hierarchical directives, documenting compliance, fulfilling bureaucratic requirements. State institutions and their administrators cooperate because formal and informal mechanisms require them to assist in “maintaining social stability,” and because non-cooperation in an environment of heightened security concerns could bring institutional trouble. Private actors such as landlords and employers face a painful calculus: cooperation harms their material interests, losing tenants or employees without compensation, yet they fear that refusal will bring consequences upon themselves. Remote participants may act from ideological alignment, personal grievance, or the pursuit of online traffic that generates income (Liao 2024). What sustains the matrix is that each actor can always find sufficient justification for their participation. This capacity for rationalization is what makes the matrix self-reproducing: no one needs to see themselves as an agent of repression, yet repression is collectively accomplished. Table 1 sets out the actors mobilized by the matrix, the domains each can access, and the repressive functions each performs.

Normalization of extralegal and arbitrary practices

A defining feature of the repression matrix is its reliance on extralegal and arbitrary practices rather than formal legal procedures. Each mobilized actor commands a unique domain of discretionary power; coordinated, these domains create comprehensive pressure

that no single institution could achieve alone, which is why the matrix requires their participation. Extralegal practices, while officially unauthorized, are so widely institutionalized that they function as routine mechanisms of control. Arbitrary practices operate within nominally legal frameworks but apply rules selectively and punitively against targeted individuals. Together, these practices blur the line between lawful administration and political persecution, creating a parallel enforcement system that maintains control while evading accountability.

These practices take multiple forms. The most common extralegal practice is the informal police summons euphemistically called “drinking tea” (喝茶 hecha)—encounters that lack legal documentation, occur in informal settings, and offer no procedural protections.

²⁵As one activist described: “The police interrogated me for several hours and made me promise not to tell anyone about it”. ²⁶

Illegal surveillance and intrusion operate without legal authorization. Cameras are installed outside activists’ doors without warrants; police and their proxies enter homes and workplaces without legal basis. ²⁷Movement restrictions are imposed without documentation—activists are placed under house arrest or prevented from attending events, all without formal prohibition or written orders. ²⁸

Relational retaliation extends repression to activists’ social networks. In one case, police visited an activist’s mother’s former employer within an hour of the activist resisting harassment. ²⁹

²⁵ See note 4.

²⁶ Interview with J9.

²⁷ Interview with J2, J3, J8, J10.

²⁸ Interview with J3, J10, J21.

²⁹ Interview with J19.

Arbitrary contract termination occurs when landlords and employers terminate agreements prematurely without cause or compensation. Administrative obstruction blocks routine services without explanation—business registrations are rejected, hukou transfers are blocked, with no reasons provided. Arbitrary institutional decisions apply rules selectively to punish targeted individuals—universities reject theses on grounds that “the topic is too sensitive”;³⁰ internet platforms delete accounts citing “posting harmful information.”³¹

What makes these practices effective is built-in deniability. Actions are undocumented, officers use pseudonyms, activists sign notices but receive no copies. Activists can hardly trace, verify, or contest what has happened to them.

Insert Table 1 here

Structural vulnerabilities and the repression matrix

Feminist activists in China inhabit a distinctive structural position shaped by their rejection of normative life paths. In Chinese society, women are encouraged to seek stable employment—often in the state sector—and to conform to gender expectations: marriage, motherhood, dependence on family (Whyke, Wang, and Lopez-Mugica 2024). Conformity provides economic security and social legitimacy; deviation forfeits these protections while inviting social hostility. Many feminist activists have chosen to reject these paths. As one explained:

My friends and I have had excellent educations and could easily secure ‘respectable’ and ‘stable’ employment. Our parents have consistently urged us to lead conventional lives and avoid involving ourselves in matters deemed inappropriate. Yet

³⁰ Interview with J15.

³¹ “女權被炸號，我起訴了微博，看看新浪回應了啥？！” (Nüquan bei zhahao, wo qisu le Weibo, kankan Xinlang huiying le sha?!, My Feminist Account Was Deleted, I Sued Weibo—See How Sina Responded!), China Digital Times, 2021, <https://chinadigitaltimes.net/chinese/664851.html> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

instead of pursuing lucrative corporate positions, marriage, and motherhood, we have chosen to become full-time women's rights advocates.³²

This choice carries structural consequences that repression can exploit. The following subsections examine three dimensions of vulnerability: housing precarity, social nonconformity and isolation, and network fragility.

Housing precarity

From the 2000s through 2020, housing prices in China soared, particularly in major cities,³³ making property ownership increasingly unattainable for lower-income women. Many feminist activists, freelancers or NGO employees with modest incomes, reside precisely where feminist communities are active and housing is most expensive.

The normative pathway for Chinese women to secure stable housing runs through marriage and family (Fincher 2023). This may involve combining a husband's higher income to purchase property together, inheriting family-provided housing upon marriage, or receiving financial support from both sets of parents. Many feminist activists, however, choose not to marry or are lesbian, effectively excluding them from these pathways to housing security (Hou 2020).³⁴

The result is that most feminist activists are renters, dependent on landlords who can be pressured by authorities. Eviction thus becomes a routine tactic deployed against them. Among 25 interviewees, 17 did not own housing in their cities; 10 had experienced eviction because of their activism. One activist was forced to move five times in a single year:

³² Xiao Meili, "China's Feminist Awakening," The New York Times, 13 May 2015, <https://www.nytimes.com/2015/05/14/opinion/xiao-meili-chinas-feminist-awakening.html> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

³³ "China's Property Market: From Boom to Crisis," The Economist, 15 October 2022, <https://www.economist.com/finance-and-economics/2022/10/15/chinas-property-market-from-boom-to-crisis> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

³⁴ See note 30.

Only after losing stable housing do you realize how important having a home is. Not being able to feel secure even in your own bed is truly terrifying.³⁵

A related issue is *hukou*. China's household registration system has long been disconnected from actual residence patterns—living in a city where one lacks *hukou* registration has become commonplace. However, when activists encounter trouble with authorities, lacking local *hukou* can become grounds for being driven out of a city entirely.³⁶

Social nonconformity and isolation

Feminist activists are often visibly “different” in their communities. Many are lesbian or queer; many present themselves in ways that defy conventional gender norms—short hair, dyed hair, tattoos. They typically live alone or with other women rather than with husbands or male partners. In neighborhoods where residents know each other's routines, these differences make activists easily identifiable, not as political dissidents, but simply as women who do not conform.

This visibility becomes a resource for repression. When police seek to mobilize other actors against activists, they can invoke gender deviance rather than political activity. One landlord was told that her two feminist tenants were lesbians, their sexuality framed as the issue rather than their activism.³⁷ A community surveillance officer identified his target as “a girl who looks like a boy,”³⁸ marking gender nonconformity itself as grounds for monitoring. By translating political targeting into the language of moral and sexual deviance, authorities make cooperation easier for actors who might hesitate to participate in overtly political repression but feel comfortable acting on gender prejudice.

³⁵ See note 14.

³⁶ Interview with J3, J11, J21.

³⁷ See note 13 and note 14.

³⁸ Interview with J20.

Network fragility

In Chinese society, family functions as a gendered safety net (Ikels 2004; Yan 2009). Women are expected to maintain close ties with parents, to obey and care for them. In return, family provides housing, financial assistance, emotional support, and social connections that can be mobilized when needed.

Many, though not all, feminist activists have become estranged from families who disapprove of their choices. Parents urge daughters to abandon activism, find stable jobs, get married, and live “normal” lives. When daughters refuse, relationships rupture, persist under strain, or retain surface harmony while activists conceal their feminist lives.³⁹

Feminist activists turn to alternative networks—informal mutual aid within feminist circles, sharing housing information, providing temporary shelter, lending money, and offering emotional support. These networks become their primary source of stability, providing support that their families cannot or will not offer. Yet precisely because these networks are so vital, they become key targets for authorities. Authorities employ multiple tactics to fragment feminist solidarity. Activists are warned against associating with “problematic” figures—specific individuals are named, with threats of consequences for continued contact.⁴⁰ Police spread misinformation to sow distrust, suggesting that one activist informed on another, or that certain individuals are responsible for bringing trouble to the group.⁴¹ Activists with surveillance cameras installed outside their doors can no longer invite friends to visit, lest they be photographed.⁴² Police also deliberately prevent activists they consider having core influence from traveling to other cities to meet with fellow activists,

³⁹ Interview with J1, J2, J3.

⁴⁰ Interview with J4, J21.

⁴¹ See note 14.

⁴² Interview with J2, J3, J8, J10, J20.

severing not only local connections but also the broader geographic ties that sustain national feminist networks.⁴³

The most effective pressure, however, comes from activists themselves. Fearing that their presence endangers others, targeted feminists voluntarily withdraw from their communities. They reduce attendance at gatherings. They can no longer chat casually with friends online.⁴⁴ They delete contact information from their phones. One activist explained: “Subconsciously, I felt this protected them and protected me.”⁴⁵ This self-imposed isolation, born of care for others, accomplishes what direct repression might not: the dissolution of solidarity networks without authorities having to explicitly forbid association.⁴⁶

These three dimensions demonstrate how non-spectacular repression exploits structural vulnerabilities: it does not create them but activates conditions already embedded in society, operating through the very social arrangements feminists have challenged.

Case study: Repression, resistance, and withdrawal

This section traces how the matrix operates in practice through the experience of one activist, Y, from her initial involvement in feminist organizing through her departure from China.⁴⁷ Her trajectory reveals the matrix’s key characteristics—identification, distributed enforcement, escalating extralegal practices—while illuminating how activists respond, how

⁴³ Interview with J11, J23.

⁴⁴ Qiao Qiao 喬喬, “訪談 | 一個女權行動者的‘三年疫情’” (Fangtan: Yi ge nüquan xingdongzhe de ‘san nian yiqing’, Interview: A Feminist Activist’s ‘Three Years of the Pandemic’), Chinese Feminism, 31 March 2024, <https://chinesefeminism.org/2024/03/31/feminist-activist-covid-interview/> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

⁴⁵ Interview with J5.

⁴⁶ “看不見的鬥爭：憂鬱與社會參與” (Kan bu jian de douzheng: Youyu yu shehui canyu, The Invisible Struggle: Depression and Social Engagement), Artforum China, 4 March 2019, <https://www.artforum.com.cn/slant/11958> (accessed on 15 January 2026).

⁴⁷ Unless otherwise noted, the account in this section, including all quotations, is based on the author’s interview with Y.

the matrix adapts to resistance, and how it ultimately achieves demobilization through sustained pressure.

Y's trajectory: An overview

Y began participating in feminist activism as a university student in the early 2010s. Her first encounters with police were relatively mild—she recalled feeling no strong sense of insecurity at the time. Several years later, she took on a leadership role in an underground feminist organization. To escape escalating harassment, she relocated to City A, which had a relatively relaxed political environment and an active feminist community.

In City A, Y rebuilt her team and formed close bonds with local feminists. But following an anti-sexual harassment campaign, she and her housemates faced “fire safety inspections” and forced evictions. Surveillance intensified: property management began monitoring her office, and by 2019, she discovered cameras installed outside her apartment door. She realized authorities “had already gathered a lot of information about me and knew that I was the head of our organization.”

Y relocated again to City B, where repression was less visible but feminist allies scarce. She launched online campaigns during the pandemic and attempted to establish local infrastructure—applying for *hukou* transfer and business registration—but both were arbitrarily rejected. Evictions continued. To break the cycle, she purchased an apartment in the distant outskirts, exhausting her savings.

Police harassment became routine. During a politically sensitive period in early 2021, she was placed under house arrest. The adjacent apartment appeared to have been requisitioned as a surveillance post. By late 2021, Y made the decision to leave China.

Response with community support

Faced with repression, Y consistently fought back, aiming to raise costs for her persecutors, reclaim a sense of agency, and educate the feminist community about authoritarian governance. In City A she refused eviction, sent legal letters, negotiated compensation, and publicized encounters on social media; in City B she installed her own camera to document surveillance. Yet she identified 2019 as a watershed: before then, “although the harassment was annoying, we still had the strength to fight back.” Afterward: “We could only silently endure.” Publicizing repression, she recognized, had become counterproductive in an environment of fear.

Feminist community remained Y’s most vital resource. In City A, collective analysis of police tactics helped her and her partners deconstruct fear (Goodwin and Pfaff 2001). She recalled: “I felt a deep sense of reassurance, having a group of people who trusted each other, who would think together about how to respond.” Police accordingly targeted these networks directly, spreading misinformation and warning against mutual visits. As Y put it:

My sense of security was utterly destroyed. I stopped inviting people over.

In City B, isolation was acute: no partners to share housing, no one physically present during crises. Community persisted across distance through video calls, mailed gifts, and visits, staying with her until departure, though some relationships ruptured under strain.

Cumulative exhaustion and the collapse of possibility

The matrix’s ultimate effect was gradual exhaustion: the depletion of material resources, psychological resilience, and the capacity to imagine a future.

Material exhaustion accumulated incrementally. Each relocation meant lost deposits, moving costs, and estrangement from social circles. When facing eviction alone in City B, Y contemplated homelessness: “I actually thought about ending up on the streets, carrying a backpack, camping in a park.” Purchasing property broke the cycle but exhausted her resources entirely.

Psychological damage accumulated. During house arrest, she described falling into desperation:

Suicidal thoughts would involuntarily appear in my mind. Standing by the window, I thought maybe one day when I couldn't bear it anymore, I would jump.

She developed sleep disturbances and experienced significant weight loss.

After leaving China, Y relegated feminist activism to a spare-time pursuit. She stopped using WeChat, severing contact with many in China. She no longer speaks publicly under her real name because authorities continue to probe for information and threaten her family.

Y described “a strong feeling of deprivation deep inside” and loss of confidence in life:

I have no plans for my life. Life is unstable. I cannot have good thoughts about the future.

Assessing feminist activism, she no longer expects “to bring about major social change”: “‘They’ can easily erase our actions and bring even more destructive consequences.”

Y's trajectory demonstrates how the matrix achieves its objectives. She was never arrested or imprisoned, never charged with anything, yet she was progressively expelled from every space where her life and work were grounded, with no dramatic moment of persecution to spotlight and no identifiable party to hold accountable. The matrix strikes at political subjectivity rather than the physical body: Y still cares about feminism, but her political identity as an activist has faded. Most profoundly, her conviction that “‘they’ can easily erase our actions” shows the state's overwhelming power internalized as unquestionable fact. The matrix transforms coercion into self-limitation, and state power into an internalized horizon of the possible.

Demobilization across the movement

To examine broader patterns of demobilization produced by the repression matrix, I analyzed the current status of the 25 activists interviewed. Nearly half of the sample (48%) have either significantly faded from feminist activism or left China due to repression. Another 7 interviewees have shifted to low-visibility forms of engagement: anonymous online participation, private support roles, or intermittent involvement that avoids public identification. Only 6 interviewees have maintained their previous level of activism. Among the 13 who had worked full-time for feminist organizations, none maintained their previous level of activism; all either faded from activism, left China, or shifted to low-visibility engagement. This includes all four who had served as organizational leaders.

None of these exits resulted from criminal prosecution; they followed prolonged exposure to the mechanisms described above. Withdrawal unfolded gradually and in silence, as continuing became progressively harder; it can rarely be attributed to a single decision or a distinct turning point, yet it ultimately left individuals feeling they had no other choice.

Those who shifted to low-visibility engagement described it as a strategic retreat: maintaining commitment while reducing exposure and adapting to the compression of activist space. Those who maintained their previous level of activism may have experienced relatively lighter repression or found ways to continue despite threats, whether by keeping professional identities as cover or by engaging entirely anonymously. Notably, none of them had been full-time organizers. Their persistence does not undermine the matrix's effectiveness; rather, it indicates that demobilization operates selectively, striking hardest at those with greater structural vulnerabilities and more central positions in the movement.

The shift to low-visibility engagement should not be read as the matrix falling short. What the matrix aims to eliminate is never private conviction but action that is visible, organized, and cumulative. Low-visibility engagement is thus no midpoint between persistence and exit but the matrix's most economical victory: control achieved without the

costs of outright elimination, in which individuals retain their convictions while their presence as public political actors disappears.

The aggregation of these individual trajectories amounts to more than their sum. What the movement loses is not particular participants but the infrastructure it lives on: organizational memory, the capacity to coordinate across groups, and the channels through which newcomers enter. Potential participants who observe these trajectories absorb the lesson before ever acting, extending the matrix's deterrent effect to a generation that has never directly encountered it. This is how demobilization at the individual level, accumulating case by case, resolves the puzzle posed at the outset: a movement can be dismantled without mass criminalization.

This analysis does not claim causal identification. Other factors, including organizational life cycles, resource depletion, changes in platform governance, pandemic restrictions, and shifting political opportunities, may also have contributed to these trajectories. What the data suggest is that the repression matrix operates as a significant mechanism through which demobilization occurs.

Conclusion

This paper has examined how non-spectacular repression operates in authoritarian China to dismantle feminist political agency. Drawing on empirical material from the Chinese feminist movement between 2013 and 2023, it demonstrates that repression need not be spectacular or physically violent to be politically devastating. Instead, it manifests through routinized, socially embedded mechanisms—surveillance, administrative harassment, housing eviction, employment sabotage, and digital erasure—that cumulatively erode activists' capacities to organize, speak, and endure.

To analyze these dynamics, I have used the term “repression matrix” to describe a dispersed yet coordinated pattern of coercion that operates across institutional, community,

and intimate spheres. The matrix operates through identification and assessment of targets, activation of multi-actor networks, distributed enforcement across diverse actors, and normalization of extralegal and arbitrary practices. Its effectiveness depends on exploiting structural vulnerabilities—housing precarity, social isolation, network fragility—that feminist activists disproportionately inhabit. Repression exploits gendered vulnerabilities, the consequences of rejecting normative life paths that society already punishes, rather than deploying overtly gendered forms of violence. It is enacted not only by state agents but also by quasi-state and non-state actors, collapsing the boundaries between political and private, legal and extralegal (Wedeen 1999). The trajectory of activist Y shows this system in motion: never arrested or charged, she was nonetheless progressively expelled from every space where her life and work were grounded, until external coercion became self-limitation.

This study speaks to two scholarly conversations. First, it advances repression studies by analyzing how everyday, dispersed, and relational modes of coercion can be more durable and damaging than episodic crackdowns, contributing to understanding of the “repression paradox” (Magaloni 2008; Lorentzen 2014). Second, it foregrounds intersectional vulnerability—particularly the entanglement of gender, household registration, urban precarity, and normative life-course expectations—as a structural condition that authoritarian power exploits to produce political incapacitation (Crenshaw 1991; Bayat 2007). By analyzing how repression is experienced, negotiated, and adapted to, the study reveals the strategic calculations through which feminists resist, and are reshaped by, authoritarian control.

This study has limitations. It describes the matrix’s operation but does not analyze conditions triggering activation, explain variation in resistance capacity, or compare across regimes. The sample focuses on urban, educated activists. Future research could examine how movements navigate repression across different contexts.

Table 1: Actors and Functions in the Repression Matrix

	Actor	Domain of Access	Repressive Functions
State coercive agencies	Police and state security	Legal authority, physical force, administrative records	Interrogation ("tea" summons), surveillance, travel restrictions, detention, refuse <i>hukou</i> transfer, coordinate other actors
	Bureau of Industry and Commerce	Business registration	Deny registration, revoke licenses, cite technical violations
State administrative agencies	Cultural authorities	Event permits, public activities	Cancel permits, shut down screenings, ban gatherings
	Public health bureaus	Health regulations	Issue eviction orders under disease control pretexts
Quasi-state actors	Universities	Education, credentials	Block thesis defense, refuse to grant degrees, threaten disciplinary action, threaten to contact family
	Community personnel (residential committees, property management)	Residential access, daily monitoring	Home inspections, reporting, accompany police visits, tracking
Private actors	Employers	Livelihood	Contract termination, hostile work environment, pressure to resign
	Landlords	Housing	Forced eviction, lease termination, refusal to renew
	Family members	Emotional ties, intimate relationships	Pressured to persuade activists to withdraw from activism
	Acquaintances and relatives	Social networks, personal information	Transmit pressure, gather intelligence
Digital actors	Internet platforms	Digital presence, communication	Account deletion, content censorship, data sharing with authorities
	Online participants	Reputation, social standing	Doxxing, rumor spreading, harassment campaigns

Source: Author, 2026.

Acknowledgments

This paper was inspired by the #MeToo in China exhibition in 2019. Mona Lena Krook's research led me to undertake this study, and Rosalynd Southern offered early support. For generous comments and suggestions, I thank RAN Ran, WU Wei-Ting, Jyl JOSEPHSON, Nancy Yun TANG, and the participants of the 2024 IQMR panel, the 2025 Gender and Politics Conference, and the 2026 IRW seminar at Rutgers University. I am grateful to all of my interviewees, and to Emma and XIAO Meili for sharing their records. HOU Yue has been a constant source of encouragement.

References

- BAYAT, Asef. 2007. "A Women's Non-Movement: What It Means to Be a Woman Activist in an Islamic State." *Comparative Studies of South Asia, Africa and the Middle East* 27(1): 20-34.
- BIDDULPH, Sarah. 2007. *Legal Reform and Administrative Detention Powers in China*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- BRAY, David. 2005. *Social Space and Governance in Urban China: The Danwei System from Origins to Reform*. Stanford: Stanford University Press.
- CAI, Yongshun. 2008. "Power Structure and Regime Resilience: Contentious Politics in China." *British Journal of Political Science* 38(3): 411-32.
- CHAN, Kam Wing, and Will BUCKINGHAM. 2008. "Is China Abolishing the Hukou System?" *The China Quarterly* 195: 582-606.
- CHEN, Xi. 2020. "Civic and Noncivic Activism under Autocracy: Shifting Political Space for Popular Collective Action." *Mobilization: An International Quarterly* 25(SI): 623-40.
- CHEN, Chiuayan, and Xiying WANG. 2020. "#MeToo in China: Affordances and Constraints of Social Media Platforms." In Jennifer EARL and Robert PERRIN (eds.), *Platforms, Protests, and the Challenge of Networked Democracy*. Cham: Palgrave Macmillan. 253-69.
- CRENSHAW, Kimberlé. 1991. "Mapping the Margins: Intersectionality, Identity Politics, and Violence against Women of Color." *Stanford Law Review* 43(6): 1241-99.

- DAVENPORT, Christian. 2007. *State Repression and Domestic Democratic Peace*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- DELLA PORTA, Donatella. 2014. "Life Histories." In Donatella DELLA PORTA (ed.), *Methodological Practices in Social Movement Research*. Oxford: Oxford University Press. 262-88.
- DENG, Yanhua, and Kevin J. O'BRIEN. 2013. "Relational Repression in China: Using Social Ties to Demobilize Protesters." *The China Quarterly* 215: 533-52.
- EARL, Jennifer. 2003. "Tanks, Tear Gas, and Taxes: Toward a Theory of Movement Repression." *Sociological Theory* 21(1): 44-68.
- EARL, Jennifer. 2011. "Political Repression: Iron Fists, Velvet Gloves, and Diffuse Control." *Annual Review of Sociology* 37: 261-84.
- FERREE, Myra Marx. 2004. "Soft Repression: Ridicule, Stigma, and Silencing in Gender-Based Movements." *Research in Social Movements, Conflicts and Change* 25: 85-101.
- FINCHER, Leta Hong. 2016. "China's Feminist Five." *Dissent* 63(4): 84-90.
- FINCHER, Leta Hong. 2023. *Leftover Women: The Resurgence of Gender Inequality in China* (2nd ed.). London: Zed Books.
- FRANCESCHINI, Ivan, and Kevin LIN. 2019. "Labour NGOs in China: From Legal Mobilisation to Collective Struggle (and Back?)." *China Perspectives* 2019(1): 75-84.
- FRANCESCHINI, Ivan, and Elisa NESOSS. 2018. "State Repression of Chinese Labor NGOs: A Chilling Effect?" *The China Journal* 80(1): 111-29.
- FU, Diana. 2017. "Fragmented Control: Governing Contentious Labor Organizations in China." *Governance* 30(3): 445-62.
- FU, Hualing. 2018. "The July 9th (709) Crackdown on Human Rights Lawyers: Legal Advocacy in an Authoritarian State." *Journal of Contemporary China* 27(112): 554-68.
- GALLAGHER, Mary E. 2017. *Authoritarian Legality in China: Law, Workers, and the State*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- GERSCHEWSKI, Johannes. 2013. "The Three Pillars of Stability: Legitimation, Repression, and Co-optation in Autocratic Regimes." *Democratization* 20(1): 13-38.
- GOODWIN, Jeff, and Steven PFAFF. 2001. "Emotion Work in High-Risk Social Movements: Managing Fear in the US and East German Civil Rights Movements." In Jeff GOODWIN, James JASPER, and Francesca POLLETTA (eds.), *Passionate Politics: Emotions and Social Movements*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press. 282-302.

- GREITENS, Sheena Chestnut. 2016. *Dictators and Their Secret Police: Coercive Institutions and State Violence*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- HILDEBRANDT, Timothy. 2013. *Social Organizations and the Authoritarian State in China*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- HINER, Hillary. 2018. "Putting the Archive in Movement: Testimonies, Feminism, and Female Torture Survivors in Chile." In Kathryn R. BEAULIEU, Anna LEAHY, and Sara CRAWLEY (eds.), *Beyond Women's Words*. London: Routledge. 204-16.
- HOU, Lixia. 2020. "Rewriting 'the Personal Is Political': Young Women's Digital Activism and New Feminist Politics in China." *Inter-Asia Cultural Studies* 21(3): 337-55.
- HOWELL, Jude. 2019. "NGOs and Civil Society: The Politics of Crafting a Civic Welfare Infrastructure in the Hu-Wen Period." *The China Quarterly* 237: 58-81.
- HUANG, Qianru. 2023. "Anti-Feminism: Four Strategies for the Demonisation and Depoliticisation of Feminism on Chinese Social Media." *Feminist Media Studies* 23(7): 3583-98.
- IKELS, Charlotte (ed.). 2004. *Filial Piety: Practice and Discourse in Contemporary East Asia*. Stanford: Stanford University Press.
- JOHNSTON, Hank. 2019. "The Dynamics of Resistance and Rule in High-Capacity Authoritarian States." In Nicole DEITELHOFF, Verena KEMPF, Jannik PFISTER, and Philip WALLMEIER (eds.), *Rule and Resistance Beyond the Nation State*. Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield. 157-77.
- LEE, Ching Kwan, and Yonghong ZHANG. 2013. "The Power of Instability: Unraveling the Microfoundations of Bargained Authoritarianism in China." *American Journal of Sociology* 118(6): 1475-508.
- LEVITSKY, Steven, and Lucan A. WAY. 2010. *Competitive Authoritarianism: Hybrid Regimes after the Cold War*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- LI, Piper, Hyunyi CHO, Yixi QIN, and Anqi CHEN. 2021. "#MeToo as a Connective Movement: Examining the Frames Adopted in the Anti-Sexual Harassment Movement in China." *Social Science Computer Review* 39(5): 1030-49.
- LIAO, Sara. 2024. "The Platformization of Misogyny: Popular Media, Gender Politics, and Misogyny in China's State-Market Nexus." *Media, Culture & Society* 46(1): 191-203.
- LIAO, Sara. 2025. "Unpopular Feminism: Popular Culture and Gender Politics in Digital China." *Communication and the Public* 10(2): 86-93.

- LIAO, Sara, and Luwei Rose LUQIU. 2022. “#MeToo in China: The Dynamic of Digital Activism against Sexual Assault and Harassment in Higher Education.” *Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society* 47(3): 741-64.
- LORENTZEN, Peter. 2014. “China’s Strategic Censorship.” *American Journal of Political Science* 58(2): 402-14.
- MAGALONI, Beatriz. 2008. “Credible Power-Sharing and the Longevity of Authoritarian Rule.” *Comparative Political Studies* 41(4-5): 715-41.
- MANN, Michael. 1984. “The Autonomous Power of the State: Its Origins, Mechanisms and Results.” *European Journal of Sociology* 25(2): 185-213.
- MATTINGLY, Daniel C. 2019. *The Art of Political Control in China*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- MINZNER, Carl. 2011. “China’s Turn Against Law.” *American Journal of Comparative Law* 59(4): 935-84.
- MOSS, Dana M. 2014. “Repression, Response, and Contained Escalation under ‘Liberalized’ Authoritarianism in Jordan.” *Mobilization: An International Quarterly* 19(3): 261-86.
- O’BRIEN, Kevin J. 2023. “Neither Withdrawal nor Resistance: Adapting to Increased Repression in China.” *Modern China* 49(1): 3-25.
- PILS, Eva. 2018. *Human Rights in China: A Social Practice in the Shadows of Authoritarianism*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- READ, Benjamin L. 2012. *Roots of the State: Neighborhood Organization and Social Networks in Beijing and Taipei*. Stanford: Stanford University Press.
- RITTER, Emily Hencken. 2014. “Policy Disputes, Political Survival, and the Onset and Severity of State Repression.” *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 58(1): 143-68.
- SCOGGINS, Suzanne E. 2021. *Policing China: Street-Level Cops in the Shadow of Protest*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press.
- SCOGGINS, Suzanne E., and Kevin J. O’BRIEN. 2016. “China’s Unhappy Police.” *Asian Survey* 56(2): 225-42.
- SPIRES, Anthony J. 2011. “Contingent Symbiosis and Civil Society in an Authoritarian State: Understanding the Survival of China’s Grassroots NGOs.” *American Journal of Sociology* 117(1): 1-45.
- STERN, Rachel E., and Jonathan HASSID. 2012. “Amplifying Silence: Uncertainty and Control Parables in Contemporary China.” *Comparative Political Studies* 45(10): 1230-54.

- STERN, Rachel E., and Kevin J. O'BRIEN. 2012. "Politics at the Boundary: Mixed Signals and the Chinese State." *Modern China* 38(2): 174-98.
- SUTTON, Barbara. 2018. *Surviving State Terror: Women's Testimonies of Repression and Resistance in Argentina*. New York: NYU Press.
- SVOLIK, Milan W. 2012. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- TEETS, Jessica C. 2014. *Civil Society under Authoritarianism: The China Model*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- TRIPP, Aili Mari. 2010. "Toward a Comparative Politics of Gender Research in Which Women Matter." *Perspectives on Politics* 8(1): 191-7.
- WANG, Yuhua. 2014. "Empowering the Police: How the Chinese Communist Party Manages Its Coercive Leaders." *The China Quarterly* 219: 625-48.
- WANG, Yuhua, and Carl MINZNER. 2015. "The Rise of the Chinese Security State." *The China Quarterly* 222: 339-59.
- WEDEEN, Lisa. 1999. *Ambiguities of Domination: Politics, Rhetoric, and Symbols in Contemporary Syria*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- WHYKE, Thomas W., Zheng WANG, and Julia LOPEZ-MUGICA. 2024. "State Feminism with Chinese Characteristics: The Inextricable Link between Women's Political Representation and Political Episteme in Contemporary China (2013–2023)." *Asian Journal of Women's Studies* 30(4): 363-90.
- XU, Feng. 2009. "Chinese Feminisms Encounter International Feminisms: Identity, Power and Knowledge Production." *International Feminist Journal of Politics* 11(2): 196-215.
- YAN, Yunxiang. 2009. *The Individualization of Chinese Society*. Oxford: Berg.
- YANG, Mayfair Mei-hui (ed.). 1999. *Spaces of Their Own: Women's Public Sphere in Transnational China*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.
- ZHU, Han, and Jun LU. 2022. "The Crackdown on Rights-Advocacy NGOs in Xi's China: Politicizing the Law and Legalizing the Repression." *Journal of Contemporary China* 31(136): 518-38.